Godwin Abuh Faruna

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Education

Kaduna Polytechnic, Kaduna, Nigeria 2014–2019
Higher National Diploma (HND), Electrical and Electronics Engineering
CGPA: 3.2/4.0 (Upper Credit)
Focus: Control Systems and Numerical Methods

Publications

G. A. Faruna, T. J. Zhang, M. Masiak, C. Ugwuanyi, and Z. Jin. Does Activation Steering Transfer Across Languages for Safety? [Long Paper]. Under review at ACL Rolling Review (ARR), October 2026.

G. A. Faruna, R. Mihalcea, and D. Dementieva. Tracing and Steering Text Detoxification Representations in Multilingual Language Models. [Long Paper]. Under review at ACL Rolling Review (ARR), October 2026.

N. K. M, S. Tanwisuth, and **G. A. Faruna**. Detectability Inversely Tracks Disruption: Reference-Free, Static-Weight Detection of Backdoored LoRA Adapters. [Long Paper]. Under review at the International Conference on Learning Representations, 2027 (ICLR '27).

G. A. Faruna. Cross-Lingual Transfer of Activation-Space Refusal Anchoring Against Adaptive GCG Attacks. [Short Paper]. To appear in GlobalSouthAI Workshop at the Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems, 2026 (NeurIPS '26).

G. A. Faruna. Latent Space Refusal Anchoring for Low-Resource African Languages: Mechanistic Safety Recovery Without Retraining. [Short Paper]. GlobalSouthML Workshop at the International Conference on Machine Learning, 2026 (ICML '26), Seoul.

G. A. Faruna. Multilingual Jailbreak Vulnerability Benchmark and Mitigation for Low-Resource African Languages. [Short Paper]. GlobalSouthAI Workshop at the International Joint Conference on Artificial Intelligence, 2026 (IJCAI-ECAI '26).

G. A. Faruna. Refusal Centroid Drift: Mechanistic Analysis of Cross-Lingual Safety Failures in Frontier Models. [Preprint]. arXiv:2603.19273, 2026.

G. A. Faruna and K. El Bairi. When AI Forgets Its Safety: Linguistic Decay and EU AI Act Compliance Gaps. [Policy Article]. EU AI Alliance, Futurium, 2026.

On-Going Work

Persona Collapse: An Interpretability Workbench for Assistant Persona Drift in Long Conversations (Cosmos Institute Grant).

Head-Level Attribution for Refusal Circuits in Multilingual Language Models: A Follow-Up to ACDC-Style Circuit Discovery.

Cross-Lingual Transfer of Activation-Space Refusal Anchoring Against Adaptive GCG Attacks. Extending the NeurIPS '26 workshop paper into a full paper for the ICML 2027 main track (January 2027 submission).

Research Experience

Jinesis AI Lab, University of Toronto June 2026–Present
Research Assistant (Predoctoral Program) with Prof. Zhijing Jin, on the multilingual mechanistic interpretability team.

- Researching how safety-relevant representations transfer across languages, using linear probes, sparse autoencoders, and activation interventions.
- Built a controlled multilingual planner, tool-caller and critic pipeline: across seven languages, low-resource languages often fail at the planner role, and the unsafe plan

can pass the critic.

- Tested role-targeted activation steering: planner-only steering helped in some low-resource settings; critic-only and joint steering were inconsistent.
- First author on *Does Activation Steering Transfer Across Languages for Safety?*, currently under review at ACL Rolling Review.

AI Explorers Program, University of Michigan July 2026–Present

Researcher with Prof. Rada Mihalcea and Dr. Daryna Dementieva. Studying how multilingual LLMs encode and suppress toxic content; first author on the ARR detoxification paper above.

- Extended paired detoxification data to isiXhosa and Yoruba (453 and 441 pairs) with a human-verified semi-synthetic pipeline.
- Combined multi-seed linear probes, sparse-autoencoder feature inventories, and activation interventions selected on development data, then tested them on a frozen split against negated and random controls.

BlueDot Impact, Technical AI Safety Project Sprint

Independent research with BlueDot mentorship. Lead researcher on LSR-Anchoring, a training-free activation-steering method that restores safety refusals in low-resource African languages.

- Designed the method end to end: prompt-set construction, native-speaker vetting for Igala and Yoruba, evaluation on Llama-3-8B, Llama-3.1-70B, Mistral-7B-Instruct, and Qwen2.5-7B, bootstrap CI analysis, and paper writing.
- Recovered near-ceiling refusal on 70B models from English-derived directions (Yoruba and Igbo SRR 0.99); SAE-derived steering removed benign-prompt collapse for Igbo and Igala at 3.5–7× lower KL divergence than mean-difference steering. First interpretability-based safety work on Igala.
- Stress-tested the method against adaptive GCG attacks, replicating Nasr et al. (2025): static anchoring cut English attack success from 1.00 to 0.60, and a white-box adaptive attacker reached only 0.80 at nearly twice the optimizer cost. The English-only anchor fully transferred to Igbo (ASR 0.00).
- Identified a language-agnostic refusal feature (Feature 112639, layer 12, EleutherAI SAE on Llama-3-8B); direct logit attribution shows it promotes the Yoruba negation particle *kò lè* alongside English refusal tokens.
- Replicated and extended ACDC-style circuit discovery (Conmy et al., 2023) on Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct across English, Yoruba, Hausa, and Igala; circuit-targeted steering preserved benign helpfulness better than global residual-stream steering.
- Measured assistant-persona drift over 30-turn conversations on Llama-3-8B in English, Hausa, and Yoruba, finding domain shapes persona more than language, with the weakest anchoring in metacognitive conversations.
- Ported cross-lingual red-teaming benchmarks to the UK AI Security Institute's Inspect platform and built LSR Workbench, a public Hugging Face Space for red-teaming and steering experiments.

Nigerian Religious Coalition on AI December 2024–Present

Technical Lead. Coalition facilitated by the Future of Life Institute (FLI).

- Leading the technical AI safety roadmap for West Africa, with a focus on cross-lingual safety standards.
- Designing a Linguistic Integrity Stack to detect semantic and safety decay in AI deployed in regional languages.

Industry Experience

Fagmart LLC February 2023–June 2026

Senior Software Engineer

- Architected backend services that cut API latency by 25% for thousands of active users.
- Ran containerised deployments on GCP with Docker and Kubernetes at 99.9% uptime.
- Mentored junior engineers on security-first coding, system design, and CI/CD.

Teaching & Facilitation

Advanced Computer Applications and AI/ML Fundamentals. Training for 100+ senior staff, Federal Ministry of Innovation, Science and Technology, Abuja, November 2024.

Systemic Risks of Frontier AI in the Global South. Training for a national coalition of journalists, with the Future of Life Institute, Abuja, March 2026. Featured on AIT *News Hour*.

AI Red Lines. Media briefing for religious leaders, Nigerian Religious Coalition on AI, Abuja, July 2026.

Facilitator, Successif Early-Career Peer Support Program Aug.–Oct. 2026

Organizer, BlueDot Impact Community Meet and Greet, Abuja February 2026

Media

Emerging Technologies in Africa and Nigeria. Television interview, Sunshine TV, June 2024.

Awards

2026 Cosmos Institute Summer Grant, Persona Collapse interpretability workbench – US$5,000

2026 BlueDot Impact ICML Travel Grant, for presenting SAE-derived steering against cross-lingual and multi-agent persona drift – US$3,500

2026 BlueDot Impact Rapid Grant, LSR-Anchoring Phase 2: ICML Sprint Scale-Up (Dense vs. MoE) – US$800

2026 Jinesis AI Lab Compute Reimbursement, multilingual multi-agent experiments – US$500

2026 BlueDot Impact Community Event Grant, Abuja Meet and Greet – US$200

2026 BlueDot Impact Rapid Grant, Linguistic Safety Robustness: An Inspect-Eval Benchmark – US$150

2026 Google Cloud TPU Compute Grant – 32 on-demand and 32 spot TPU v4, 64 spot TPU v6e, and 64 spot TPU v5e chips

References

Prof. Rada Mihalcea
Professor of Computer Science and Engineering, University of Michigan

Prof. Zhijing Jin
Assistant Professor of Computer Science, University of Toronto

Dr. Daryna Dementieva
Postdoctoral Researcher, Technical University of Munich